

# CRISIS BRIEFING: "The Friday Counterfeit"

**To:** Operational Task Force (all teams)

**Classification:** Urgent. Do not distribute outside this room.

**Current time:** Friday, 2:00 PM

**Deadline for action:** 5:00 PM (3 hours from now)

## 1. The Situation

You are the **Operational Task Force** for **Bleu Hen Hospitality Group**, the most talked-about farm-to-table restaurant group in Delaware.

*"Raised Close. Served Honest."*

Three locations: **Bleu Hen Bistro** (Wilmington Riverfront, the flagship), **The Bleu Hen Roost** (Main Street, Newark) and **Bleu Hen Brasserie** (Greenville). About 140 employees, many of whom live on tips. Your Owner started with one 40-seat bistro in 2015 and built it into a three-time winner of "Best Farm-to-Table in the First State." Every menu carries one promise in print:

*"Every bird, every cut, every catch: raised, grown or caught within 75 miles of your table."*

That promise is why guests pay about 40% more here than anywhere comparable. It is not marketing on top of the business. **It is the business.**

### Tonight is the biggest night of the year

It is **Friday, February 13th**, the start of Valentine's weekend. All three restaurants are completely booked, and your signature offering is **The Lovebird Tasting**, a five-course dinner for two at \$185 a couple. The marquee dishes have names that appear on every menu card:

- **Fifty-Mile Flounder** with brown butter
- **Sussex Hen Roulade**
- **Brandywine Pork Duo**
- **Surf & Turf for Two**

Every dish credits one farm by name: **Brandywine Heritage Farms & Fisheries**, your exclusive supplier. The founder, Calvin Teague, is a local celebrity. He has a handshake with half the Chamber of Commerce. He has eaten at your bistro. Your Executive Chef calls him by his first name.

There are **1,130 reservations** this weekend. Some of them are first dates. Some are anniversaries. At least a few are marriage proposals; the Riverfront staff has been quietly arranging them for weeks. A table of 14 at the Bistro is booked for a retirement party. The Greenville dining room has a state official's table reserved for Saturday.

### Then, at 1:41 PM, this happened

A local investigative food reporter, **Jo Alvarez** of *The Delmarva Dispatch*, posted a teaser on social media (see **Exhibit A**). She says the "local, sustainable" supplier behind a three-location restaurant group is repackaging cheap, factory-farmed product from out-of-state industrial processors and selling it as local. She says she has a paper trail. She says the story publishes at **5:00 PM today**.

She did not need to name you. There is exactly one restaurant client in the state with a three-location footprint and an exclusive Brandywine contract.

At 1:30 PM, Alvarez emailed your Marketing Director for comment and gave you until **4:00 PM** to respond on the record.

The teaser has been shared more than 1,200 times in 19 minutes. Your reservation system shows **14 cancellations since 1:41**. Two local TV newsrooms have called. Your phones at the Bistro are ringing and the host stand does not know what to say.

### What is in your walk-in coolers right now

Every walk-in at all three locations is stocked with Brandywine product for tonight's service: chicken, pork, flounder, rockfish and some beef. **\$40,000 of it, paid for and sitting there**. The sous chefs have already started tonight's prep. Flounder was portioned this morning. The roulade was rolled at noon.

### What you know, and what makes you nervous

**On Tuesday**, the Riverfront sous chef, **Tess Aguilar**, peeled a shipping sticker off a delivery box and found a second label underneath, with an out-of-state plant code. She took a photo, but it's blurry. She sent it to Chef Rafi Moreno, who replied: *"Pallets get re-boxed all the time. Don't worry about it."* Today he hasn't said much at all.

### Other things that look bad:

- Brandywine's invoices dropped **14% in November**. Teague called it "volume pricing."
- Chef Rafi has noticed the "heritage" pork has lacked its usual marbling for about three weeks.
- Alvarez's teaser says she has a "paper trail."

### Other things that suggest it might not be true:

- You visited Brandywine's farm twice. The last visit, in September, looked genuine.
- The state agriculture department inspected their home farm last spring, and it passed.
- The teaser has no specifics. Perhaps only some products are affected.
- Teague has years of goodwill, and 60 people in Sussex County work for him.

**What you don't know:** Which products? Since when? What does Alvarez actually have? Whether Teague knew your Owner would be exposed.

**You will not be able to find out by 5:00 PM.** You must decide anyway.

### Who's in the building

| PERSON           | ROLE                               | MOOD                                                                           |
|------------------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Owner        | Founder. Your boss.                | Time-starved, panicked, very proud of the brand. Waiting on you.               |
| Chef Rafi Moreno | Executive Chef, all three kitchens | Fiery and loyal. Feels responsible. Defensive if blamed. Follows clear orders. |
| Tess Aguilar     | Sous chef, Riverfront              | Anxious. Wonders whether she should have pushed harder on Tuesday.             |
| Priya Nair       | Group General Manager              | Calm. Worried about the staff and their tips.                                  |
| Lena Cho         | Marketing Director                 | Phone is blowing up. Wants to "get ahead of it."                               |
| Hal Brandt       | Outside counsel                    | Careful. "Don't say anything you can't prove."                                 |

### Your calendar for the next three hours

| TIME    | WHAT HAPPENS                                                                           |
|---------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2:00 PM | You convene.                                                                           |
| 4:00 PM | Alvarez's deadline for an on-the-record comment.                                       |
| 4:15 PM | <b>Staff lineup</b> at all three locations. This is when servers get told what to say. |
| 5:00 PM | <b>The article publishes. Doors open.</b>                                              |
| 5:30 PM | First seatings at the Bistro and the Roost.                                            |
| 6:00 PM | Local TV crews expected outside.                                                       |

## 2. The Stakes

|                                                 |                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sunk inventory in the coolers                   | \$40,000                                                                               |
| Projected weekend revenue at risk               | \$200,000 (1,130 covers, about \$177 average check)                                    |
| Gift certificates already sold for this weekend | \$18,000                                                                               |
| Annual supplier spend                           | About \$1.1 million, under a <b>3-year exclusive contract with 18 months remaining</b> |
| Jobs                                            | About 140 at Bleu Hen, plus about 60 at Brandywine                                     |
| Time until the article drops                    | <b>3 hours</b>                                                                         |

Every path costs something. Throwing out the inventory and canceling reservations means certain, immediate losses. Serving the product means betting the brand on not getting caught. Pulling it could also mean a fight with the supplier, a contract dispute, or hurting people who may be innocent. **Doing nothing is also a decision.**

### Exhibits

Five exhibits come with this briefing as separate handouts:

| EXHIBIT | WHAT IT IS                                           |
|---------|------------------------------------------------------|
| A       | The reporter's teaser post (1:41 PM)                 |
| B       | The reservation board and cancellation log (2:00 PM) |
| C       | Text thread: sous chef Tess and Chef Rafi            |
| D       | The Lovebird Tasting menu                            |
| E       | The reporter's email to Marketing (1:30 PM)          |

## 3. Your Mission

Decide what the restaurant group does **today**, and communicate it clearly to three audiences. There is no answer key. You will be judged on the quality of your judgment, the clarity of your communication, and how well you defend your choices under pressure.

## 4. Required Deliverables

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Your team must produce **all three**. Respect the length limits exactly.

### Deliverable 1: BLUF Memo to the Owner (exactly 3 sentences)

Addressed to the Restaurant Group Owner, advising the overall strategy.

Lead with the Bottom Line Up Front: what you recommend, what it costs, and what you need from the Owner.

### Deliverable 2: 3-Point Operational Pivot for the Executive Chef (exactly 3 points)

Directives, not suggestions. Together the three points must cover:

- What to do with the **current food** in the coolers.
- What to **serve tonight**.
- Anything the Chef must do before service begins.

### Deliverable 3: Front-of-House Guest Script (exactly 2 sentences)

What servers and hosts say to guests **when the article drops at 5:00 PM**. It will be taught at the 4:15 PM staff lineup, so a server must be able to say it naturally, at a table, to a nervous couple celebrating Valentine's Day, without looking at a card.

## 5. Rules of Engagement

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- **Teams:** Two teams of 10. You are competing against another team facing the same crisis, and the Owner will hear both plans.
- **Prep time:** 25 minutes in the War Room.
- **Pitch time:** 3 minutes to pitch, followed by about 8 minutes of questioning from the Owner.
- **Spokespeople:** Elect **1 or 2** spokespeople to deliver the pitch. Everyone contributes to the plan.
- **Everyone must be ready to answer.** During questioning, the Owner may turn to **any member of your team** and demand an answer. Nobody gets to hide behind the spokespeople.
- **Deliverables lock at 45:00.** You will hand in a copy of all three deliverables before the Gauntlet. No edits after that.
- **Pitch order is drawn at the start of the Gauntlet.** The team pitching second will wait outside the room during the first pitch, so prepare as if you could be first.
- **Expect interruptions.** The Owner is stressed, short on time and will cut in early and often. Be ready to answer a question mid-sentence and pick your pitch back up.
- **Don't read to the Owner.** Notes are fine. A script read aloud is not.
- **Be ready for new information.** Conditions may change during the War Room. A team that cannot adapt will not survive the Gauntlet.

## 6. Suggested Way to Work (optional)

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Ten people cannot all write one 3-sentence memo. Splitting the work is allowed and recommended, as long as the final package is consistent.

- **Strategy squad (about 3):** decides the overall strategy and drafts the BLUF memo.
- **Kitchen squad (about 3):** drafts the Chef's 3-point operational pivot.
- **Guest squad (about 3):** drafts the 2-sentence front-of-house script.
- **Spokesperson(s) (1 or 2):** sit in with each squad, own the pitch structure, and make sure all three deliverables tell the **same story**.

Reconvene as a full team by **minute 40** and use the last 5 minutes to check that your three deliverables don't contradict each other. Contradictions between deliverables are exactly the kind of thing the Owner will find.

## 7. Pitch Structure

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Use this order. Every second counts.

1. **Current State:** where we stand, in one or two sentences.
2. **Proposed Action:** what we do, starting with the BLUF.
3. **Immediate Cost:** what this costs in dollars and consequences, with no sugarcoating.
4. **The Ask:** the specific decision or resource you need from the Owner, right now.

## 8. Questions to Consider

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*These are prompts, not hints toward a right answer.*

- What do you know, what do you not know, and what can you find out before 5:00 PM?
- Who is harmed by each option, and who finds out about it?
- Which option can you recover from, and which can you not?
- Who in the building needs to hear from you first?

*The clock starts when your facilitator says go.*